

example, if you're working in, say, MS Word, the OS requires information such as what font to use, what each menu should contain, etc. This required data is stored in the registry. The registry is thus a warehouse for Windows' configuration data and that of other applications as well.

Since variable data is stored in the Registry, you can set Windows XP's behaviour to your preferences by tweaking it correctly. By default, XP allows customising certain variables via the Control Panel settings. However, for finer customisation, you'll need to manually tweak the variables in the Registry.

8.4.2 The Registry Inside Out

Similar to the Service Management Console that allows tweaking of Windows XP services, XP comes with a Registry Editor. To invoke it, go to Start > Run, type in "regedit", and press [Enter].

As you can see above, the registry has five main branches which separate the data stored in the registry into five different groups. The main branches have folders under them called 'Keys', which hold the values for the variables. It is important to understand the five main branches and their purpose.

HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT: As the name suggests, this holds the root data, that is, the data required for Windows XP's internal functioning, such as the OLE (Object Linking and Embedding). It also acts as a database for file associations, which determines the application to be launched when a file is double-clicked. It is not advisable to do any tweaking in this branch, as it is very complex and offers zero margin for error.



A view of the Registry Editor